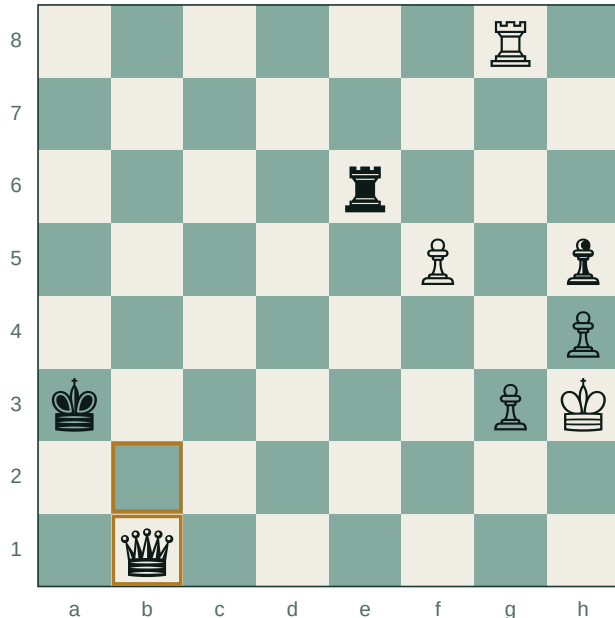


Queen-and-rook endings: White, move 54

Queen-and-rook endings

White to move



Previous move: 53...b1=Q. Gold borders mark its start and finish.

WORKED CONTINUATION - COVER THIS SECTION FIRST

54. Ra8+ Kb4 55. Rb8+ Kc5 56. Rxb1

54.Ra8+ Check restricts Black to 4 legal replies here. Recorded reply: **54...Kb4**.

55.Rb8+ Check restricts Black to 7 legal replies here. Recorded reply: **55...Kc5**.

56.Rxb1 The rook captures the queen on b1.

At the end, nominal material is White 8 / Black 6 (P=1, N/B=3, R=5, Q=9). Over this line, White's balance changes by +9. Activity and king safety still affect the evaluation.

CHECKPOINT

Using P=1, N/B=3, R=5, Q=9, how much does White's material balance change over the complete line? **Answer:** +9: the balance goes from -7 to +2. Count promotions and every recapture, not just the first gain.

CARRY THE IDEA INTO YOUR GAMES

Do not activate the king as casually as in a pure pawn ending. The remaining heavy pieces can still generate a mating net.

WHAT THIS POSITION TEACHES

When queens and rooks remain, mating threats coexist with endgame pawn races. Coordination and king shelter remain essential even on a sparse board.

HOW TO LOOK

Look for heavy-piece batteries, skewers, and checks that force a defender away from a promotion square or pawn.

The defending king is on a3. Geometrically undefended: rook on e6 and queen on b1. Check for tactical protection.